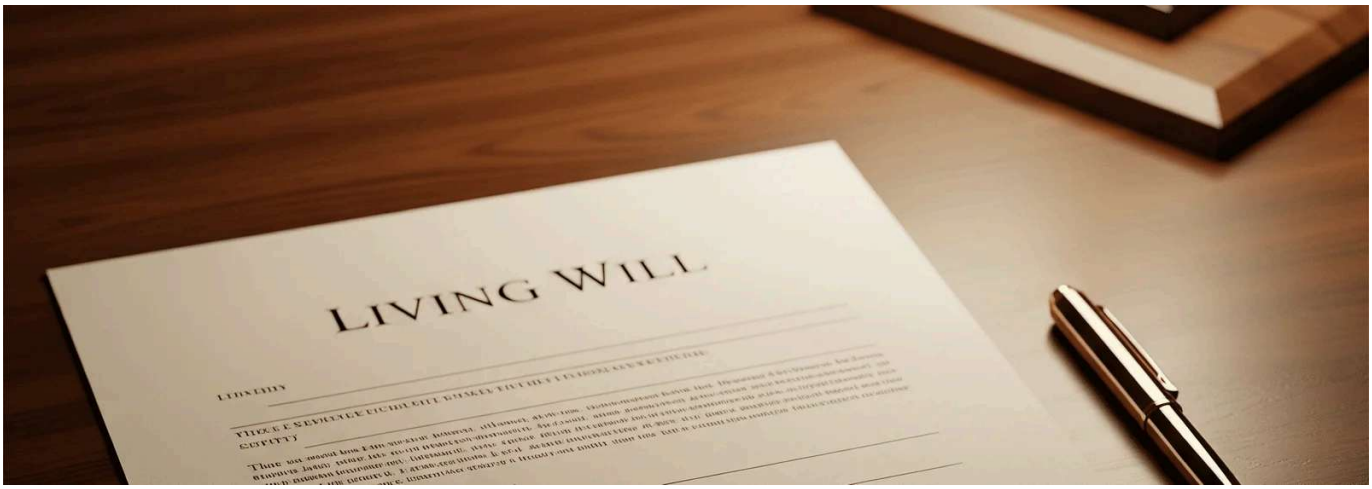
Dr. Abhishek Gandhi
Advocate, Delhi High Court

English



Living Wills in India: A Complete Guide to End-of-Life Autonomy and Legal Framework

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Introduction

In a country where the idea of end-of-life decisions often gets clouded by cultural, religious, and familial sentiments, the concept of a **Living Will** emerges as a beacon of personal dignity and medical autonomy. Often misunderstood or overlooked, **Living Wills** are a powerful legal document that allows individuals to voice their healthcare preferences in situations where they may no longer be capable of making those decisions themselves.

In March 2018, the Supreme Court of India, in the landmark judgment of *Common Cause v. Union of India*, legally recognized the right to die with dignity as a fundamental right under Article 21 of the Constitution. This paved the way for the legal enforcement of **Living Wills** or **Advance Medical Directives**.

This article provides a detailed, legally informed, and practically relevant understanding of Living Wills in the Indian context, answering frequently asked questions and outlining the procedure, safeguards, and legal implications.

What is a Living Will?

A **Living Will** is a written document in which a person (referred to as the "executor" or "testator") voluntarily states his or her wish regarding medical treatment in case he or she becomes terminally ill or incapacitated and is unable to express informed consent.

It primarily pertains to **withholding or withdrawing life-support measures**, such as ventilators, feeding tubes, or resuscitation, when recovery is deemed medically futile.

Legal Nature

Background: The Supreme Court's Landmark Decision

The need for Living Wills found judicial legitimacy through the **Supreme Court's Constitution Bench decision in 2018**, which held that the right to die with dignity is a part of the **right to life** **under Article 21**.

The Court laid down:

1. The right of a terminally ill patient to **refuse medical treatment or life support**.
2. The **validity of Advance Medical Directives** or Living Wills.
3. A **strict procedural mechanism** for execution and implementation.

In 2023, the Supreme Court simplified the process, making it easier for citizens to create and enforce Living Wills.

Key Features of a Living Will

Feature	Description
Executor	The person making the Living Will. Must be an adult with sound mental faculties.
Content	Specifies treatment preferences, such as DNR (Do Not Resuscitate), withdrawal of ventilators, or refusal of aggressive interventions.
	When the executor becomes

Feature	Description
Witnesses Required	At least two adult witnesses are mandatory.
Medical Board Review	A team of doctors must review and approve the application of the will.
Magistrate's Role	Must be submitted to the **Jurisdictional Judicial Magistrate First Class (JMFC)**.

Who Can Make a Living Will?

Any adult citizen of India who:

- Is of **sound mind**,
- Is **capable of understanding** the consequences of their decision,
- Is acting **voluntarily** and **without duress**, and
- Is not suffering from any **mental illness or cognitive impairment** at the time of writing the directive.

How to Make a Valid Living Will in India?

As per the latest simplified Supreme Court guidelines (2023), here is the **step-by-step process**:

1. Drafting the Living Will

- Specific medical treatments to be refused (e.g., CPR, mechanical ventilation, dialysis).
- A declaration that the will becomes effective only if the executor is terminally ill or permanently unconscious.
- Appointment of a **guardian or surrogate** to ensure the will is followed.

2. Attestation and Witnessing

- The Living Will must be **signed in the presence of two independent adult witnesses**.
- A copy must be submitted to the **Jurisdictional JMFC**, who will countersign and maintain a digital and physical record.

3. Preservation of the Document

- One copy is retained by the executor.
- One copy is with the JMFC.
- One copy may be provided to the hospital or treating physician, if known.

When Does a Living Will Come into Force?

A Living Will is **activated** only when:

- The executor is **incapacitated** or in a **permanent vegetative state**.
- The attending physician concludes that further treatment is **medically futile**.
- A **Medical Board** is constituted, comprising senior medical professionals.
- If the Board concurs, the matter is presented to the JMFC for confirmation.
- On approval, the withdrawal of life support is permitted.

To ensure the Living Will is not misused:

- Only **qualified physicians** and a **multi-specialty board** can recommend discontinuation of life support.
- The **Judicial Magistrate** oversees the implementation to prevent foul play.
- The process is subject to **transparent documentation and verification**.
- Family consent is **not mandatory**, though they may be consulted.

Difference Between Living Will and Euthanasia

Aspect	Living Will	Euthanasia
Nature	Passive – withdrawing life support	Active – administering lethal agent
Legality in India	Legal (with guidelines)	Illegal under Indian law
Consent	Expressed in advance	Usually sought at the time
Example	Refusing ventilator or dialysis	Lethal injection

Importance of a Living Will

- **Respects Autonomy**: Gives individuals control over their medical fate.
- **Reduces Family Burden**: Removes emotional dilemma from the family.

Can a Living Will Be Revoked?

Yes. The executor can **revoke or modify** the Living Will **at any time**, provided:

- They are of sound mind.
- The revocation is in writing and duly signed.
- A copy of the revocation is sent to the **JMFC and treating physician**.

Limitations of a Living Will

- **Lack of awareness** among the public and medical fraternity.
- **Administrative delays** in convening medical boards.
- **Hospital hesitancy** in acting upon such directives.
- **Family resistance** can cause emotional and procedural hurdles.

Living Will vs Power of Attorney for Healthcare

Aspect	Living Will	Medical Power of Attorney
Focus	Specifies treatments to refuse	Appoints someone to make decisions
Activation	Only when incapacitated	Only when incapacitated
Control	Direct instructions by executor	Decision-making by surrogate

Best Practices for Creating a Living Will

1. **Consult a Legal Expert** to draft a clear and valid directive.
2. **Discuss with Family** to ensure emotional preparedness.
3. **Mention Specific Treatments** (e.g., feeding tube, ventilator, resuscitation).
4. **Update Regularly** based on medical condition or changing wishes.
5. **Preserve Copies Securely** with hospital records, family, and your lawyer.

International Perspective

In many countries, Living Wills are a part of **Advance Directives**, legally recognised under statutory provisions:

Country	Legal Status
USA	Recognised under state laws
UK	Valid under Mental Capacity Act 2005
Canada	Varies by province
Australia	Permitted under common law/statute
India	Recognised via Supreme Court ruling

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

No. A Living Will deals with **medical preferences** during a person's lifetime when they are incapacitated. A Last Will deals with **property and estate distribution** after death.

Q2. Can my family override my Living Will?

No. Once a Living Will is validly executed and medically justified, it cannot be overridden by family members.

Q3. Is notarization required?

No. As per the Supreme Court guidelines, attestation by two witnesses and submission to JMFC is sufficient.

Q4. Can I mention organ donation in a Living Will?

Organ donation preferences can be expressed, but it is advised to register separately with the appropriate organ donation registry.

Q5. Can I include religious or spiritual wishes?

Yes. Non-medical preferences such as rituals, prayers, or choice of place of passing may be included optionally.

Conclusion

A **Living Will** is not a pessimistic document. It is a testament to the maturity of a society that values individual dignity, medical ethics, and autonomy. In India, with the recognition by the Supreme Court, it is now both legally and morally significant to create a Living Will, especially for those with terminal illnesses, chronic conditions, or advancing age.

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Advocate (Dr.) Abhishek Gandhi

Dr. Abhishek Gandhi is a practicing Advocate before the Delhi High Court and various other courts across Delhi. The team working with Advocate Gandhi consists of seasoned advocates, engineers, doctors, chartered accountants, company secretaries, and retired government officials. Together, they form a dedicated and highly skilled group of legal professionals with expertise spanning civil, criminal, commercial, immigration, techno-legal, and employment-related matters.

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